

Vintage Guide

What makes a great year · How climate shapes the wine · Key vintages 2004–2023 · kazmicellars.com

A 'vintage' is the year the grapes were harvested. In some regions, vintage matters enormously — a great Burgundy year produces wines that age for decades; a poor year produces wines to drink young or avoid. In others (Champagne NV, most Sherry, many New World wines) vintage matters little. Understanding what vintage tells you — and when to pay attention to it — is the mark of a confident wine buyer.

WHAT MAKES A GREAT VINTAGE?

Winter	Cold enough to trigger full dormancy (resets the vine's biological clock) but not so cold as to cause frost damage to permanent wood. Adequate but not excessive rainfall to recharge soil moisture reserves for the growing season ahead.
Spring — Bud Break	Mild, frost-free conditions are critical. A late frost after bud break can destroy an entire harvest in a single night — and occurs with devastating frequency in Burgundy, Champagne, and Bordeaux (2017 and 2021 were particularly frost-damaged years).
Spring — Flowering	Warm, calm, dry conditions during the 10-day flowering window allow complete and even pollination. Rain or cold during flowering causes coulure (poor fruit set) and millerandage (uneven berry size) — both reduce yield and quality.
Summer — Ripening Season	Even ripening requires steady warmth without extreme heat spikes. Heat waves (above 35–40°C) stress the vine, causing uneven ripening and potential flavor issues. Some summer rainfall is beneficial but excess promotes disease (mildew, botrytis).
Harvest — September/October	Dry conditions at harvest are ideal — rain dilutes flavor and promotes botrytis. The timing of harvest is crucial: picking before a rain event, or after the rain clears, is one of the most pressure-filled decisions in winemaking.
Growing Season Length	A long, gradual ripening season generally produces the most complex wines. When grapes ripen slowly over many weeks, they develop more aromatic compounds and better acid-sugar balance than in short, hot seasons.
Vintage Variation by Region	Cool climate regions (Burgundy, Champagne, Mosel, Barolo) show the most vintage variation — a degree or two of temperature difference profoundly changes the wine. Warm, consistent climates (Napa, Barossa, Douro) show less variation, which is why New World wines are more reliable year to year — but also less thrilling when great vintages occur.

VINTAGE RATING GRID 2004–2023

Ratings below reflect general consensus across major critics and regional bodies. Individual producers always outperform or underperform their vintage. ★★★★★ = Outstanding ★★★★★ = Excellent ★★★ = Good ★★ = Average ★ = Challenging

Year	Bordeaux Left Bank	Bordeaux Right Bank	Burgundy Red	Burgundy White	Champagne (Vintage)	Northern Rhône	Tuscany (Barolo/Chianti)	Rioja	Napa Valley	Barossa Valley
2004	★★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★
2005	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★
2006	★★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	N/A	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★
2007	★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★	N/A	★★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★★★	★★★★
2008	★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★★
2009	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	N/A	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★

2010	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	N/A	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★
2011	★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★	N/A	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★
2012	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★
2013	★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★	★★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★
2014	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	N/A	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★
2015	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★
2016	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
2017	★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★
2018	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★
2019	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★
2020	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	N/A	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★
2021	★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★★
2022	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★
2023	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	N/A	★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★

★★★★★	Outstanding — benchmark year, buy and cellar
★★★★	Excellent — well above average, reliable quality
★★★	Good — solid but less concentration or balance than top years
★★	Average — drink early, choose producers carefully
★	Challenging — difficult conditions, selective buying essential

NOTABLE VINTAGES — DEEPER NOTES

2016 — The Benchmark Modern Vintage

Across Bordeaux, Northern Rhône, Rioja, and Barossa, 2016 is considered one of the decade's defining vintages. In Bordeaux, the Left Bank produced structured, age-worthy Cabernets with perfect ripeness and freshness. The Rhône produced concentrated, age-worthy Syrahs. Rioja produced Gran Reservas that may outlive most people reading this. Buy and cellar.

2015 — Sun, Warmth, and Generosity

A warm, generous vintage across most of Europe — fruit-forward, opulent, and approachable. Less structured than 2016 but more immediately pleasurable. Outstanding in Burgundy (both red and white), Tuscany (especially Barolo), and Napa. Many 2015 wines are drinking beautifully now and will continue to do so.

2019 — The Precision Year

Produced fine, precise wines across multiple regions — particularly impressive in Burgundy (some compare it to the legendary 2010) and Northern Rhône. Bordeaux produced elegant, earlier-drinking wines than the more structured 2016 and 2018. Champagne declared widely.

2010 — The Benchmark of the Decade

Widely considered the finest vintage of the 2010s across Bordeaux, Burgundy, and the Rhône. Perfect ripeness with exceptional acid structure — the hallmark of a vintage that will age magnificently. 2010 Burgundy Premier and Grand Cru are among the most treasured bottles produced this century. Worth seeking out if you can afford it.

2017 — The Frost Year

A catastrophic spring frost in April 2017 devastated large portions of Burgundy, Champagne, Chablis, and the Loire Valley. Some estates lost 80–90% of their crop. Wines that were made are often excellent — low yields concentrated what remained — but quantities are tiny and prices high. The Rhône and Barossa were largely unaffected and produced very good wines.

2018 — Champagne's Finest Modern Year

2018 produced the most widely declared Champagne vintage in recent memory. Warm, ripe, and with excellent acid balance. Also exceptional in Bordeaux (opulent Left Bank), Alsace, and the Rhône. Wines are rich and concentrated — those with structure will age magnificently.

2005 — The Classic

Before 2010, 2005 was the standard by which modern Bordeaux vintages were judged. Both Left and Right Bank produced powerful, concentrated wines with excellent aging potential. Burgundy was equally impressive. At 20 years old, 2005 Bordeaux is now entering its drinking window — the window that may last another 20–30 years.

2022 — The Climate Change Vintage

A defining vintage for a new era. Exceptional heat across Europe produced wines of extraordinary ripeness and concentration — but also raised questions about alcohol levels and balance. Outstanding in Burgundy, Barossa, and Bordeaux. The wines are powerful and rich; whether they will age as classical vintages do remains to be seen. A fascinating marker of how climate is reshaping what a great European vintage looks like.

■ *On climate change and vintages: the definition of a 'great vintage' is shifting. Cooler regions (Burgundy, Champagne, Mosel) are now producing reliably ripe wines in years that would previously have been considered challenging. Warmer regions (Barossa, Napa) are struggling with excessive heat and alcohol. The vintage chart of 2030 will look very different from the one of 2000. The wines being made today in previously 'too cool' regions may be some of this century's most exciting — but they won't be there much longer.*